a bit clearer

PYTHON AND AI · EPISODE 05

PyCharm vs VS Code

Set Up Your Python Editor

KEY POINTS

- An **IDE** (Integrated Development Environment) puts writing, running and debugging your code in one app, and helps as you type.
- **VS Code** (48%) and **PyCharm** (25%) are the two most popular main editors for Python.
- This course uses **PyCharm**: everything for Python is built in, and the core features are **free forever**.
- Download it from **jetbrains.com/pycharm**, pick x64 or ARM64, click through Setup, then **Skip Import** on first launch.

01 Why an IDE

▶ VIDEO 00:00

Notepad has no idea you're writing Python: no suggestions, every letter typed by hand, and mistakes stay hidden until you run the program.

missing_bracket.py — PYTHON

```python
# This file raises an error on purpose: the closing bracket is missing.
# Notepad shows nothing wrong; Python stops with: SyntaxError: '(' was never closed
print("Hello World"
```

Terminal

```
> python missing_bracket.py
  File "missing_bracket.py", line 3
    print("Hello World"
          ^
SyntaxError: '(' was never closed
```

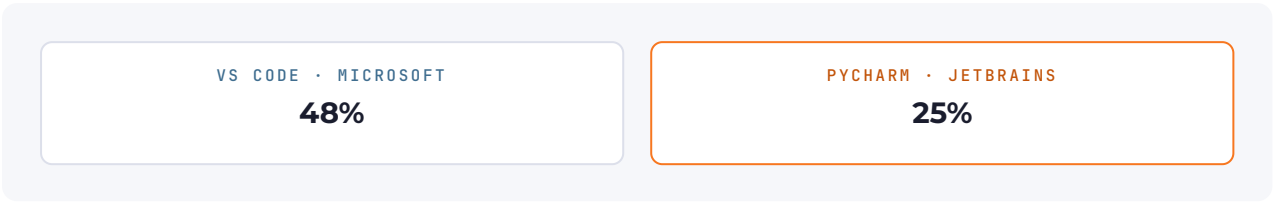
KEY IDEA

An **IDE** suggests what comes next as you type and underlines mistakes **before** you run the code.

02 The Two Big Choices

▶ VIDEO 00:52

FIGURE 5.1 **Main editor for Python development**



Python Developers Survey (PSF & JetBrains), results published 2025. Together, almost three out of four.

- **VS Code**: free, lightweight, works with almost any language. A general editor: add the **Python extension** first.
- **PyCharm**: built just for Python. Code suggestions, error checking, running and debugging are there from the start. Since 2025 it's one product: core features **free forever**, plus one month of Pro to try.

> KEY IDEA **Our pick**
>
> This course uses **PyCharm**: the shortest path for a beginner. Everything you learn also works in VS Code.

03 Download

▶ VIDEO 02:05

Go to **jetbrains.com/pycharm** and click **Download**. The page picks your system; on Windows choose **.exe (Windows)** or **.exe (Windows ARM64)**. Not sure? **Settings › System › About › System type**: x64 → the regular one, ARM → the ARM one. The installer is about 1 GB.

04 Install

▶ VIDEO 02:47

Double-click the installer and click **Yes**. Click **Next** through Setup (the defaults are fine), then **Install**. At the end, tick **Run PyCharm** and click **Finish**.

05 First Launch

▶ VIDEO 03:05

Tick the **User Agreement** box and click **Continue**; if it offers to import settings, click **Skip Import**. You land on **PyCharm Home**: the 30-day Pro trial starts, and when it ends you keep the free core features. The **Theme** button at the bottom switches between dark and light.

CODE 1 file on GitHub `github.com/abitclearer/python-and-ai/tree/main/05-pycharm-vs-vs-code`